

- RAG Learning

1.1 Democracy and Participation

Politics — Edexcel (9PL0) — Component 1: UK Politics, Section A

This topic opens Component 1 and supplies two of the three questions on that paper. Almost everything in it turns on one distinction: the difference between a **system of government** and the **quality of the democracy** that system delivers. The UK is unambiguously a representative democracy; whether it is a *healthy* one is the contested question, and examiners reward answers that keep the two apart.

Legitimacy — the rightful use of power in accordance with pre-set criteria or widely-held agreements, such as a government's right to rule following an election.

Direct democracy — citizens decide policy questions themselves rather than through representatives.

Representative democracy — citizens elect representatives who deliberate and decide on their behalf.

Pluralist democracy — power is dispersed among many competing groups, none of which dominates.

Democratic deficit — a flaw in the democratic process where decisions are taken by bodies lacking sufficient accountability to the electorate.

Participation crisis — the claim that citizens are disengaging from the formal processes of politics, chiefly voting and party membership.

Franchise / suffrage — the legal right to vote in public elections.

Think tank — a research organisation that develops and promotes policy ideas.

Lobbyist — a person paid to influence decision-makers on behalf of a client or cause.

1. Current systems of representative and direct democracy

	Direct democracy	Representative democracy
--	------------------	--------------------------

Who decides	Citizens decide policy questions themselves	Citizens elect representatives who decide on their behalf
Origin	Athenian assembly; Swiss cantons	Developed with the extension of the franchise from 1832
UK examples	Referendums; e-petitions; recall petitions; some local consultations	General, devolved, local and mayoral elections
Strengths	Pure popular will; no distortion by representatives; high legitimacy; educative effect on participants	Deliberation; expertise; protection of minorities; continuous accountability; practicable at scale
Weaknesses	Tyranny of the majority; complex questions reduced to binary; vulnerable to campaign effects and funding	Representatives may substitute their judgement; parties may not offer the combination a voter wants; accountability only periodic

Similarities worth stating

A common error is to treat the two as opposites. Both rest on political equality — one person, one vote — both require free expression and a genuine choice, and both confer legitimacy on the outcome. The UK combines them, and the interesting questions arise at the join rather than within either.

Referendums in the UK since 1975

Year	Question	Turnout	Result	Significance
1975	Remain in the EEC?	64.6%	67.2% Yes	First UK-wide referendum; collective responsibility formally suspended
1979	Scottish and Welsh devolution	63.6% / 58.8%	Scotland Yes but below the 40% threshold; Wales No	The only UK use of a turnout threshold — and it voided a Yes vote

1997	Scottish Parliament / Welsh Assembly	60.4% / 50.1%	74.3% Yes / 50.3% Yes	Preceded by a White Paper specifying the scheme
1998	Good Friday Agreement	81.1%	71.1% Yes	Legitimised a constitutional settlement in a divided society
2011	Alternative Vote	42.2%	67.9% No	Conceded by the Conservatives as the price of coalition; treated as settling the question
2014	Scottish independence	84.6%	55.3% No	Scotland-only; 84.6% was the highest turnout at any UK election or referendum since the introduction of universal suffrage; first major vote with 16–17-year-olds enfranchised
2016	EU membership	72.2%	51.9% Leave	Binary question, unspecified alternative; years of subsequent conflict over what it required

The pattern is the most examinable thing here. Where the alternative was **specified in advance** — 1997 devolution, with a White Paper setting out the scheme — implementation was straightforward. Where the question was binary but the alternative **undefined** — 2016 — the result conferred a mandate whose content was contested and which no institution had clear authority to determine.

Exam Tip: A 30-mark question on referendums is not really about referendums. It is about parliamentary sovereignty. The strongest answers explain that Parliament remained legally free to disregard the 2016 result and politically unable to, then draw the conclusion about where sovereignty actually sits. Note also the absence of rules: no threshold (1979 aside), no settled franchise, no agreement on when a question may be asked again.

Other direct mechanisms

- **E-petitions** — 100,000 signatures triggers consideration for a Westminster Hall debate. High visibility, no obligation to act; the 2019 petition to revoke Article 50 reached over 6 million

signatures and changed nothing.

- **Recall of MPs Act 2015** — a recall petition is triggered by a custodial sentence, suspension from the Commons for at least 10 sitting days, or a conviction for false expenses claims. If 10% of constituents sign, a by-election follows. Successful petitions: Peterborough (2019), Brecon and Radnorshire (2019), Rutherglen and Hamilton West (2023) and Wellingborough (2023). The first petition, North Antrim (2018), failed at about 9.4% of the electorate. It is not a general right of recall: voters cannot remove an MP for their voting record.

2. A wider franchise and debates over suffrage

Act	Effect	Electorate after
Great Reform Act 1832	Extended the vote to parts of the middle class; removed rotten boroughs	~7% of adults
Representation of the People Act 1867	Urban working-class men meeting a property qualification	~16%
Representation of the People Act 1884	Extended the county franchise on the same terms	~29%
Representation of the People Act 1918	All men over 21; women over 30 with a property qualification	~74%
Equal Franchise Act 1928	Equalised the voting age at 21	~97% of adults
Representation of the People Act 1969	Voting age lowered to 18	Near-universal adult suffrage
Scottish Elections (Reduction of Voting Age) Act 2015; Senedd and Elections (Wales) Act 2020	Votes at 16 for devolved and local elections	Divergent franchises within the UK

The suffrage campaigns

The **suffragists** (NUWSS, Millicent Fawcett, founded 1897) pursued constitutional methods — petitions, lobbying, peaceful demonstration. The **suffragettes** (WSPU, Emmeline Pankhurst, founded 1903) adopted direct action including arson, window-breaking and hunger strikes, met by force-feeding under the Cat and Mouse Act 1913. Historians dispute which mattered more, and the 1918 Act's timing — immediately after a war in which women's labour was indispensable — complicates both claims. The debate is a useful template for pressure group methods generally: does disruption win concessions or harden opposition?

Current debates

Votes at 16. For: at 16 a citizen may work and pay income tax, consent to medical treatment, and join the armed forces with parental consent, so excluding them from decisions that bind them is inconsistent. Voting is habit-forming, so enfranchising people while still in education and at a settled address may raise lifetime turnout; Scotland's 2014 experience saw high turnout in that group. Against: political judgement at 16 is still forming and may be more open to the influence of parents and teachers; other thresholds sit at 18, so the change creates a new inconsistency rather than removing one. Note too that the argument is not disinterested — parties polling well among young voters have most to gain. The debate is no longer hypothetical: in July 2025 the Labour government announced it would lower the voting age to 16 for all UK elections, including Westminster, before the next general election. The Representation of the People Bill was introduced on 12 February 2026 and had its Lords second reading on 14 September 2026, so as of September 2026 it is not yet law.

Prisoner voting. *Hirst v UK* (2005) held the blanket ban incompatible with Article 3 of Protocol 1 ECHR. The UK declined to comply for more than a decade; in 2017 a minimal administrative change allowed prisoners on temporary licence to vote. This example serves two topics at once: as a suffrage debate, and as evidence of the limits of rights enforcement against a determined Parliament.

Compulsory voting. For: it would eliminate turnout inequality by class and age, and remove the incentive to target only likely voters. Against: it compels participation that may be uninformed, and treats the symptom rather than the cause of disengagement.

Registration. Individual Electoral Registration, introduced in 2014, replaced household registration and is estimated to have left around 8 million eligible people unregistered or incorrectly registered. Automatic registration is the standard proposed remedy.

3. Pressure groups and other influences

Type	Definition	Examples
Sectional (interest)	Represents a specific group; membership usually restricted to those who share that position	BMA, Unite, NFU, Law Society
Promotional (cause)	Campaigns on an issue or value; open to anyone who supports the cause	Greenpeace, Liberty, Howard League, Shelter
Insider	Has consultative access to government decision-makers	BMA, CBI, RSPB, RSPCA
Outsider	No such access; relies on public campaigning and direct action	Extinction Rebellion, Just Stop Oil, Fathers 4 Justice

The typologies overlap, and saying so earns credit: many sectional groups campaign publicly, some outsider groups are outsiders *by choice* because access would compromise them, and insider status can be lost when a government changes.

Case studies of success and failure

- **Success — the Gurkha Justice Campaign (2009).** Combined a sympathetic cause, celebrity backing (Joanna Lumley), media pressure and a government with a small effective majority. Produced a Commons defeat and a policy reversal on settlement rights.
- **Success — the Snowdrop Campaign (1996–97).** Following Dunblane, it secured the Firearms (Amendment) Acts banning most handguns. Aligned with overwhelming public sentiment and faced a weak opposing interest.
- **Success — Marcus Rashford and free school meals (2020).** An individual with public standing achieved two government reversals within months, which illustrates how far media profile now substitutes for organisational access.
- **Failure — the Countryside Alliance (1998–2004).** Mass demonstrations, substantial funding and a committed membership did not prevent the Hunting Act 2004, because the group was opposed by a government with a large majority and a manifesto commitment.

- **Failure — the Stop the War Coalition (2003).** The largest demonstration in British history did not prevent the Iraq deployment, which the Commons had voted for.

The determinants are therefore: **alignment with government priorities**, **parliamentary arithmetic**, **resources**, **expertise the government needs**, and **public sympathy** — not the group's type.

Other influences

- **Think tanks** — IPPR and the Resolution Foundation on the centre-left, the Adam Smith Institute and the Institute of Economic Affairs on the right, the Centre for Social Justice on welfare; the IFS is an independent, non-partisan source of fiscal analysis used by all sides. Influence runs through supplying ideas and evidence, and is greatest where a party is developing policy in opposition.
- **Lobbyists** — the Transparency of Lobbying Act 2014 created a register of consultant lobbyists, but it covers only those lobbying ministers and permanent secretaries directly on behalf of a third party, which critics argue excludes the great majority of the activity, including in-house corporate lobbying.
- **Corporations** — influence through investment and employment decisions as much as through direct representation. The 2022 market reaction to the mini-budget is the clearest recent illustration of non-electoral power over policy.

Exam Tip: Pressure groups are the standard vehicle for a pluralism-versus-elitism question. Pluralism says power is dispersed among many competing groups; elitism says access follows resources, so corporate and professional interests reach insider status far more readily than outsider causes. The *count* of groups supports pluralism; the *distribution of access* supports elitism. The strongest judgement is that competition is real but structurally weighted.

4. Rights in context

Instrument	What it does	Limitation
Magna Carta 1215	Established that the monarch is subject to law; due process	Largely symbolic today; most clauses repealed

Human Rights Act 1998	Gives ECHR rights effect in UK courts; s.3 interpretive duty; s.4 declaration of incompatibility; s.6 duty on public authorities	An ordinary statute — repealable by simple majority. A declaration does not invalidate the provision.
Equality Act 2010	Consolidates protection against discrimination across nine protected characteristics	Enforcement depends on individuals bringing claims, with cost as a barrier
Freedom of Information Act 2000	Right of access to information held by public authorities	Wide exemptions; a ministerial veto, used over the Prince of Wales correspondence
Common law	Residual liberty — conduct is lawful unless prohibited; judicial review	No protection against Parliament legislating to prohibit

Milestone cases

- ***A v Home Secretary (2004), the Belmarsh case*** — the Law Lords held that indefinite detention of foreign terrorism suspects was incompatible with Articles 5 and 14. Parliament responded by replacing the regime with control orders. The case shows both the power of a declaration and its limits: the detention was not ended by the court but by Parliament choosing to respond.
- ***Hirst v UK (2005)*** — prisoner voting; over a decade of non-compliance.
- ***Miller (2017)*** — prerogative could not be used to remove rights conferred by statute.

Collective rights against individual rights

The recurring clash is individual liberty against collective security. Counter-terrorism legislation, the Investigatory Powers Act 2016 and restrictions on protest under the Police, Crime, Sentencing and Courts Act 2022 and the Public Order Act 2023 each restrict individual rights in the name of a collective interest. The UK has no mechanism for resolving the conflict other than Parliament's own judgement, because no court may strike down the legislation.

Exam Tip: The decisive point on rights protection is structural, not a list of statutes: the body whose power rights are meant to limit is the same body that decides whether those rights continue to exist. State that and the essay has a conclusion rather than a summary. Compare

with the US, where entrenched rights and judicial review put the question beyond a legislative majority — at the cost of handing it to unelected judges.

5. Is there a participation crisis?

Evidence for	Evidence against
Turnout fell from 77.7% (1992) to 59.4% (2001) and has not returned to pre-1997 levels	Pressure group and campaign membership has grown substantially
Party membership is far below its post-war peak, when the Conservatives alone claimed nearly 3 million	Labour membership rose above 500,000 after 2015; the SNP grew several-fold after 2014
Local and PCC election turnout is much lower still — PCC turnout has fallen below 20%	E-petitions routinely attract hundreds of thousands of signatures
Turnout among under-25s is consistently well below that of over-65s	The 2014 Scottish referendum recorded 84.6% turnout
Around 8 million people are unregistered or incorrectly registered	Single-issue mobilisation on climate and social causes draws large numbers

Proposed remedies

- **Electoral reform** — a proportional system would reduce wasted votes and end the concentration of campaigning on marginal seats. Cost: weaker direct accountability, since governments would be formed by post-election bargaining.
- **Votes at 16 and automatic registration** — enlarges the electorate, but reaches the groups already least likely to vote, so it addresses the legal barrier and not the social one.
- **Compulsory voting** — removes turnout inequality; compels uninformed participation.
- **Citizens' assemblies** — randomly selected citizens deliberate with expert evidence, as used on abortion in Ireland. Addresses the main weakness of referendums, but is advisory, so influence depends on the government's willingness to act.

- **Digital democracy** — online voting and consultation; raises security and secrecy concerns.

The defensible conclusion is that the *form* of participation has changed rather than disappeared — but that the newer forms are more episodic and more unequally distributed by class, age and education than voting is, so a shift in form is not equivalent in democratic value. The crisis, if there is one, is of **equality** of participation rather than of its quantity.

Quick recall

- UK = representative democracy with increasing direct elements since 1997
- Referendums: advisory in law, binding in practice, no threshold or franchise rules — 1979 is the one threshold case, and it voided a Yes vote
- Specified alternative (1997 devolution) implements cleanly; unspecified alternative (2016) does not
- Franchise: 1832, 1867, 1884, 1918, 1928, 1969; votes at 16 in Scotland and Wales
- Pressure group success follows access, resources and parliamentary arithmetic — not group type
- Gurkhas, Snowdrop, Rashford = success; Countryside Alliance, Stop the War = failure against a majority
- Rights rest on an ordinary statute, so on political restraint rather than entrenchment — Belmarsh shows both the power and the limit
- Participation: a crisis of equality rather than of quantity